

Laser-focused: Afshan Fathima's next target is to turn professional. "We have some offers but I'm still to decide whether I want to compete for one more World Championship and win a gold or take the jump into professional fighting," she says. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

she returned from the tournament with mixed emotions. "It stings, of course, to go so far and fall short in the final, but at the same time, I'm a little happy that I at least came this far," she says.

Few might not have predicted Afshan would get anywhere near where she's gotten. "Even I wouldn't," she says.

Mixed martial arts were never on the horizon for the 23-year-old from Anna Nagar in Chennai. Even sport wasn't really part of the picture. "There's no one in my family who has chosen sports as a career," says Afshan, the eldest of three sisters. That was the case for her as well. It wasn't as if she wasn't interested in sports. Some of her earliest memories are of watching WWE pro wrestling matches with her father and uncle. At school, she says she was one of the few children to actually make the most of the games period.

"Most of the other kids would be chatting with each other or catching up on their studies. I was the only one who would pester the games teacher to start a basketball match or something. I was also someone who used to roughhouse with my friends. They'd all tell me I was really strong or that I hit really hard. But I didn't know what I was going to do with that. While I really wanted to play something, my family only really wanted me to study. My grandmother was a teacher, and my aunt was a lecturer. I was also fairly good in studies, so I had no option but to focus on my books. Perhaps if I were a bit dull, they might have been more open to the idea of putting me in sports," she says.

It was only after her school when she began studying for a degree in Electrical Engineering at Hindustan Institute of Technology that Afshan

